The punch that landed on Adham Khan’s face was so hard, so swift, it knocked him to the ground, unconscious.

~

Five years earlier, when Bairam Khan invited his young lord to execute his first enemy, the fourteen-year-old had refused. Bairam had had to pick up a sword and cut off Hemu’s head himself.

But how long can a king baulk at vengeance and hope to retain his throne? At nineteen, having slammed Adham unconscious with his fist, Akbar did not think of trials and prisons, he did not think of Maham; he did not let calm reason come between him and his pitiless justice.

Akbar had Adham thrown head first over the balcony on which they stood. The balcony wasn’t all that high; Adham didn’t quite die. Akbar had him dragged back up the stairs, by the hair. In the time that Adham’s injured body returned – screaming, moaning, weeping, or all three – Akbar’s adrenaline would have begun to subside; he would have had time for second thoughts. But no: an emperor cannot betray his own decisions.

Akbar had Adham turned upside down and flung down again. This time, Adham’s neck broke; his head must have been twisted at an unnatural angle, with the soft jelly of his brain spilling out.

Looking down at Adham’s broken body, his own pulse racing, what did Akbar think? It was the first execution he’d ever ordered; it remains a milestone in the chronicles of his rule, proclaiming the dawn of his authority, as naked and compelling as his fist. Did he marvel a little at what he had done, what he was capable of? Or did the pounding fury in his head overpower all thought?[50]

~

‘Mama, we have killed Adham.’[51]

Maham Anaka was ill and resting when Akbar went to tell her what had happened. Bayazid writes that he told her point-blank, but Abul Fazl presents a scene of greater ambiguity, as if Akbar did not have the heart to put the brutal fact of her son’s execution in so many words: ‘Adham killed our Ataga, we have inflicted retaliation upon him.’

‘You did well,’ Maham replied.